

■ By Priya Sahgal

This could well be his personal take of *Taare Zameen Par* (stars on the ground). Last fortnight, when BJP leader L.K. Advani saw the Aamir Khan starrer, he had tears in his eyes. Perhaps, it was not the movie as much as the title that got to him. After six decades of playing post-script to Atal Bihari Vajpayee's tryst with destiny, the man consigned to be his eternal Number Two is finally getting his chance to walk on stars. Advani's wait is now officially over: both BJP and NDA have nominated him as their prime minister-in-waiting. With Vajpayee giving the recently-concluded BJP national council meet in Delhi a miss, the saffron spotlight is now firmly on Advani. They need him for both the content and the gloss, while Vajpayee will provide the background aura.

Nowhere was this more obvious than at the party's Delhi meeting as chief ministers and party leaders pledged their allegiance to Advani. "Today he is no longer the leader of BJP but of the entire nation," said BJP President Rajnath Singh. It was a historic meet in more ways than one. This was the first national council where the party formally accepted the reality of a future without Vajpayee. It was also a meet where Advani took centre stage not just as a BJP leader but as a leader of the entire NDA. His was the concluding address—traditionally reserved for Vajpayee—and he reached out not just to the committed cadres but also to BJP's coalition partners, both rhetorically and ideologically. The old Hindutva jargon that scared away allies like TDP was repackaged in more palatable terms. Article 370, Uniform Civil Code and Temple talk were replaced by more statesmanlike issues: good governance, development and internal security. The only Ram that was mentioned was Ram Setu.

Leader after leader spoke from a script that was in sync with the new Advani dharma: reach out to a BJP beyond the traditional vote bank. Whether it was Rajnath's presidential address, Arun Jaitley's political resolu-

tion, Venkaiah Naidu's farmers' resolution or Narendra Modi's chief ministerial presentation, all stressed issues of governance rather than religion: urban middle class concerns of high-interest home loans, lack of infrastructure, internal security and a demand to increase the income tax standard exemption to Rs 1.5 lakh. Farmers' issues were addressed as were tribals' and Dalits', underlining the party's search for new constituencies. Asking for a lower interest on crop loans, Rajnath said, "Sitting in Delhi we cannot even estimate the amount of fury

**There is no
pot of gold.
The task of
mining,
processing
and minting
gold is an
elaborate
exercise.**

L.K. ADVANI,
NDA'S CANDIDATE FOR PM

that villagers and farmers feel towards the Government." Since December, he has toured Vidarbha, Karnataka and Haryana, addressing farmers. Along with the urban vote, BJP is also now wooing the rural vote. And women too are a new target audience as is clear from the decision to reserve seats for them in the party. With Mayawati making a pan-Indian impact on the Dalit vote bank, BJP too feels the need to shore up its traditional base.

Conventional Hindutva rhetoric was repackaged in a softer, contemporary idiom by demanding the hanging

of Afzal Guru and criticising the minority appeasement policies of UPA. This is the new Advani speak and the language in which he will make his prime ministerial pitch in a series of rallies slated to start next month. BJP's entire campaign will be centred around a strong leader, once again. Only this time Advani will replace Vajpayee's 'tried, tested and trusted' profile. "Both Advani and Modi have been maligned for their hardline image. But in a strange way, this helps them," says Naidu. The saffron strongman has already charted out the path on which he plans to steer the BJP rath. "In the '80s and '90s, in a post-Shah Bano era, there was a need to whip up a strong Hindutva passion. BJP has not forgone this but the time now is to focus on new issues, such as development and a strong sense of nationalism," explains a party general secretary. "Issues that worked so well for BJP in Gujarat," he adds.

It's that old feel-good mood once again. Senior leader Sushma Swaraj thinks the upbeat mood started with the choice of Advani as the prime ministerial candidate. "Our first step was to appoint a strong leader. In a coalition, it is important to announce a leader well in advance, otherwise other issues are ignored and leadership issue takes centre stage. We were lucky we have a leader like Advani," she says. A decade ago, this was not the case. It was because he was unacceptable to the allies that Advani declared Vajpayee as BJP's prime ministerial candidate. Recently, Advani had trouble being accepted by his own party. What has changed so suddenly and so dramatically?

To his credit, Advani has never regretted his controversial Jinnah comments. On the contrary, his cross-border gamble seems to have worked. He had hoped that this would soften his hawkish image and make him more acceptable to the allies. Even sceptics like Nitish Kumar who had earlier balked at his hardline image have now welcomed his candidature. Advani has since been stressing the importance of coalition dharma. At the council